EVOLUTION, 1948–61

The First Kashmir War highlighted the immediate need for a command headquarters to relieve Army HQ of the day-to-day conduct of operations in north India. Initially raised as Delhi and East Punjab Command, it was redesignated as Western Command in January 1948 with Lieutenant General Kodandera Madappa Cariappa as its first GOC. In Kashmir, a temporary headquarters, the Jammu & Kashmir Force, was formed in early May 1948 with two subordinate formations, namely the Srinagar and Jammu divisions. This was due to the need to improve the coordination of operations conducted by the increasing number of brigades deployed in the state. These were the first formation headquarters raised after independence; they were subsequently to become XV Corps and 19 and 26 divisions respectively. Similarly, HQ XI Corps was raised at Ambala on 1 March 1950; it moved to Jalandhar in July 1951.

A major change undertaken by the Indian Army after 1947 was to move towards an egalitarian and broad-based regimental system. The process was initiated with the formation of the Brigade of the Guards in 1949 from three of the Army's oldest battalions: 2 PUNJAB, 1 GRENADIERS and 1 RAJ RIF. A year later, 1 RAJPUT became 4th Battalion, followed by 5th Battalion recruited from all of India's hill districts, and 6th Battalion, recruited from all of the south Indian states. The Parachute Regiment was also raised on the same 'All India, all classes' basis when the three existing parachute battalions – 1 PUNJAB (Para), 3 MARATHA LI (Para) and 1 KUMAON (Para) – were assigned to the newly formed regiment on 15 April 1952.

The Army's artillery branch underwent an expansion almost immediately after partition, with seven new regiments being raised in 1948, followed by one heavy, four medium and eight field regiments by 1957. During the mid-1950s, the anti-tank role moved from the artillery to the armoured corps; the former anti-tank regiments were converted into heavy-mortar regiments equipped with the 120mm mortar, initially imported and produced domestically from 1961.